

Priya Dhawka

Email: pdhawka@uw.edu

Website: dhawkap.github.io

Research Interests

Human Computer Interaction: Data Visualization, Politics of Open Data, Visualization Practitioners and/as Influencers, The Role of (Misleading) Data Visualizations in Problematic Information, Anthropographics & Demographic Data.

Education

- 2023– **University of Washington**, Seattle, WA
PhD in Human-Centered Design and Engineering [expected 2028]
Candidacy expected April 2026
Advised by **Dr. Jennifer Turns**
- 2023–2025 **University of Washington**, Seattle, WA
MS in Human-Centered Design and Engineering
- 2021–2023 **University of Calgary**, Calgary, Canada
MSc in Computer Science
Thesis: Demographically Diverse Anthropographics: Exploring Equitable Visual Representations of Diversity
Advised by **Dr. Wesley Willett**
- 2015 – 2019 **Colgate University**, Hamilton, NY
BA in Computer Science

Publications

CONFERENCE AND JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS ¹

* denotes equal contribution.

- [C.5] Nina Lutz, Joey Schafer, **Priya Dhawka**, Phil Tinn, and Kate Starbird. Visually-Informed Mixed Methods Research of Visual Social Data. Forthcoming, **CHI 2026**.
- [C.4] **Priya Dhawka***, Nina Lutz*, and Kate Starbird. [Data Visualizations as Propaganda: Tracing Lineages, Provenance, and Political Framings in Online Anti-Immigrant Discourse](#). **CSCW 2025**. Bergen, Norway. October 2025. *Best Paper*.

¹Within computer science, HCI, and related fields, conferences are the primary venue for academic work. Papers published at these conferences undergo rigorous review comparable to journal submissions in other fields. Students are typically named first and faculty/senior authors last in computer science and HCI research.

- [C.3] **Priya Dhawka** and Sayamindu Dasgupta. [The Social Construction of Visualizations: Practitioner Challenges and Experiences of Visualizing Race and Gender Demographic Data](#). In Proceedings of the 2025 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (**CHI 2025**). Yokohama, Japan. April 2025. [24.9% acceptance rate]. *Honorable Mention*.
- [C.2] **Priya Dhawka**, Lauren Perera, and Wesley Willett. [Better Little People Pictures: Generative Creation of Demographically Diverse Anthropographics](#). In Proceedings of the 2024 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (**CHI 2024**). Honolulu, Hawai'i. May 2024. [26.4% acceptance rate].
- [C.1] **Priya Dhawka**, Helen Ai He, and Wesley Willett. [We are the Data: Challenges and Opportunities for Creating Demographically Diverse Anthropographics](#). In Proceedings of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (**CHI 2023**). Hamburg, Germany. April 2023. [28.4% acceptance rate].

WORKSHOP PAPERS

- [W.4] Noëlle Rakotondravony, **Priya Dhawka** and Melanie Bancilhon. [Beyond English: Centering Multilingualism in Visualization](#). In *IEEE VIS 2023 Workshop on Visualization for Social Good*. Melbourne, Australia. October 2023.
- [W.3] **Priya Dhawka**, Helen Ai He and Wesley Willett. [Representing Marginalized Populations: Challenges in Anthropographics](#). In *IEEE VIS 2022 Workshop on Visualization for Social Good*. Remote. October 2022.
- [W.2] KJ Ross, **Priya Dhawka** and Wesley Willett. [People Count—Counting People: Centering the Un-counted and Misrepresented](#). In *CHI 2022 Human-Centered Data Science Workshop*. May 2022.
- [W.1] **Priya Dhawka**, Wesley Willett and Helen Ai He. [Observations of Data Resistance: Challenges of Communicating Demographic Data at Private Institutions](#). In *IEEE VIS 2021 Human-Data Interaction Workshop*. Remote. October 2021.

THESES AND NON-REFEREED PUBLICATIONS

- [N.1] **Priya Dhawka** and Wesley Willett. Humanizing Data Using Demographically Diverse Anthropographics. In *Do No Harm Guide: Crafting Equitable Data Narratives*. Urban Institute. February 2024.
- [T.1] **Priya Dhawka**. Demographically Diverse Anthropographics: Exploring Equitable Visual Representations of Diversity. *University of Calgary Faculty of Graduate Studies*. Calgary, Canada. July 2023.

Awards & Honors

2024 – 2025

2023 UW Herbold Fellowship (\$9500)
 2023 Faculty of Science Graduate Teaching Award (\$1500), University of Calgary
 2022 Alberta Graduate Excellence Scholarship (\$11,000), Province of Alberta
 2022 Departmental Research Award (\$11,000), University of Calgary
 2021 – 2023 International Graduate Tuition Award (\$3000/yr), University of Calgary
 2019 Alumni Memorial Scholar (\$6000), Colgate University
 2018 Lampert Institute Research Fellowship (\$4500), Colgate University
 2017 New York Six Upstate Global Collective (\$3600), New York Six Consortium

Service

2021 – **Reviewing:** DIS 2025, CHI 2025, CHI 2024, VIS 2023 (Vis4Good)
Student Volunteer: VIS 2023, CHI 2023, VIS 2022

2022 – 2023 **Residence Services Community Ambassador**, University of Calgary

2017 – 2018 **South Asian Cultural Club & Hindu Students' Association President**, Colgate University

2016 – 2019 **Office of International Student Services Intern**, Colgate University

2016 – 2018 **Office of Residential Life Community Leader**, Colgate University

2015 – 2017 **Office of Admission and Financial Aid Intern**, Colgate University

Mentoring

2023– **Lauren Perera**, UCalgary CS BS, working on generative text-to-image creation of demographically diverse anthropographics (published at CHI'24).

Work Experience

2019 – 2021 **Office of Equity and Diversity Data Analyst**, Colgate University
 Created visualizations and EEO/AA reports of institutional demographic data on faculty recruitment and retention for decision-makers to implement equity-focused hiring policies.

Teaching Experience

2025 **Graduate Teaching Assistant: DATA 512**, University of Washington
 Evaluated assignments and guest-lectured for **DATA 512: Human Centered Data Science** for the Masters in Data Science program.

2025 **Graduate Teaching Assistant: HCDE 492/3**, University of Washington
 Evaluated assignments for **HCDE 492 and 493: Capstone** on student capstone projects for the HCDE major.

- 2024 **Instructor of Record: HCDE 524**, University of Washington
Taught **HCDE 524: Intro to Programming Concepts** in the MS program with 20 students.
- 2024 **Graduate Teaching Assistant: HCDE 418**, University of Washington
Evaluated assignments for **HCDE 418: Critical Technical Practice** on critical theory and methods towards a liberatory practice of technology.
- 2024 **Instructor: HCDE 596/496**, University of Washington
Led a Directed Research Group on Food, Caste and Technology in Seattle.
- 2023 **Graduate Teaching Assistant: DATA 605**, University of Calgary
Designed assignments for Master of Data Science and Analytics program course, **DATA 605: Actionable Visualization and Analytics** on tools such as Tableau and PyData (Pandas, NumPy, Altair, etc) for 80 students.
- 2022 **Graduate Teaching Assistant: CPSC 599.87**, University of Calgary
Evaluated assignments for **CPSC 599.87: Visualization and Analytics** on tools including Tableau, PyData (Pandas, NumPy, Altair, etc) and Gephi for 30 students.
- 2021 **Graduate Teaching Assistant: CPSC 583**, University of Calgary
Designed assignments for **CPSC 583: Introduction to Visualization** on tools such as Tableau, Jupyter, and Processing for 52 students.
- 2018 – 2019 **Teaching Assistant**, Colgate University
Taught tutorial sections for **COSC 101 & COSC 102: Introduction to Programming** in Java and Python averaging 50 students.

Research Experience

- 2024 – **Graduate Research Assistant**, University of Washington
Ongoing research investigating the impact of practitioner positionalities and politics on the production of visualizations of race and other protected demographic data.
- 2021 – 2023 **Graduate Research Assistant**, University of Calgary
Equitable visualization approaches for representing demographic diversity in anthropographics with a focus on generative AI for rapid prototyping and data storytelling.
Advisor: Dr. Wesley Willett
- 2018 **Summer Research Student**, Colgate University
Leveraging NLP techniques to detect allergens in restaurant menus.
Advisor: Dr. Joel Sommers
- 2016 – 2018 **Research Assistant**, New York Six Upstate Global Collective
Experiences of multilingual international students at English-speaking liberal arts institutions.

Skills

Technical: Python, JavaScript, Java, SQL, Latex, Ruby, Processing, C.

Other: Tableau, D3.js, Adobe Creative Suite, quantitative and qualitative research methods.